

No Genuine Copula in Japanese: a reanalysis of 'da' as a conceptual-locative postposition plus a one-argument existential verb¹

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Abstract

This paper proposes a new analysis of the Japanese so-called copula *da* and its non-contracted form *dearu*. Traditionally, *da/dearu* has been regarded as a single copular verb equivalent to English *to be*. However, the separability between *de* and *aru* and the inseparability between preceding NPs and *de* show that this interpretation is inadequate. In sentences such as *kare=wa gakusei dearu* 'he is a student', the noun phrase *gakusei* plus *de* behaves as a single constituent, while *de* and *aru* are separable. This suggests that *gakusei de* forms a postpositional phrase (PP) and that *dearu* should be reanalysed as **the conceptual-locative postposition *de* plus the one-argument existential verb *aru***.

Under this analysis, the above sentence is syntactically an existence-asserting and domain-specifying sentence consisting of the ONE-ARGUMENT core clause *kare=wa aru* 'he exists' and the ADJUNCT *gakusei=de* 'in the conceptual domain "student"' or, more simply, 'as a student'. The non-deletability of the adjunct *gakusei=de* arises from its pragmatic and informational indispensability rather than from syntactic necessity, since it functions as the focus of the sentence. The paper also accounts for the default negation pattern *kare=wa gakusei=de=wa nai* (partial negation) instead of *kare=wa gakusei=de nai* (total negation), showing that the negator applies to the adjunct domain *gakusei=de* rather than to the existence of *kare* itself.

This reanalysis thus provides a unified account of the structure, semantics and historical development of Japanese *da/dearu* constructions.

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1. Introduction — Separability between *de* and *aru* in *dearu* and inseparability between NPs and *de*

In Japanese linguistics, *da* and *dearu* have traditionally been treated as a copula equivalent to *to be* in English, as in (1), where *dearu* can be replaced by *=da*, '=' indicating enclisis:

- (1) kare=wa gakusei dearu
 he(SUBJ)=TOP student(PRED) COP
 'He is a student.'

However, this analysis faces a major limitation: it cannot account for the **high degree of independence between *de* and *aru* in *dearu***. For example, when the noun *gakusei* 'student' is marked by the focus/additive particle — the so-called *toritatesi* in Japanese — *=mo* 'also', the sentence cannot take the form in (2):

- (2) *kare=wa gakusei =mo **dearu**
 he(SUBJ)=TOP student(PRED) also(ADD) COP
 'He is also a student.'

but must be as in (3):

- (3) kare=wa gakusei **de** =mo **aru**
 he(SUBJ)=TOP student(PRED) COP? also(ADD) COP?
 'He is also a student.'

The particle *=mo* is inserted between *de* and *aru*, as if it were an infix. Furthermore, in (4):

- (4) kare=wa gakusei **deari** kanozyo=wa syakaizin **=da**
 he(SUBJ)=TOP student(PRED) COP she(SUBJ)=TOP professional(PRED) COP
 'He is a student, she is a professional.'

the first *deari* may reduce to *de* alone as in (5):

- (5) kare=wa gakusei **de** kanozyo=wa syakaizin **=da**
 he(SUBJ)=TOP student(PRED) COP? she(SUBJ)=TOP professional(PRED) COP
 'He is a student, she is a professional.'

These facts show that ***de* and *aru* are separable**, whereas **the NP *gakusei* and *de* always remain contiguous**, as in (6):

(6) Kare=*wa* gakusei de aru.

Kare=*wa* gakusei de mo aru.

Kare=*wa* gakusei de, kanozyo=*wa* syakaizin=*da*.

Hence, in *kare=wa gakusei dearu*, the sequence *gakusei* plus *de* is assumed to constitute a single inseparable constituent, as Dalla Chiesa (2015) notes: "the NP-*de* element must always be the phrase (in the closest proximity to the verb²)", where the parenthetical remark is this paper's author's. This *gakusei de* is formally identical to a **postpositional phrase (PP) consisting of a NP + the postposition =de**. In what follows, therefore, *gakusei de* will be treated as a PP, that is, PP *gakusei=de*. This separation between *=de* and *aru* is compatible with Matsuoka's observation that "the copula *da* consists of the postposition *de* and the verb *aru*" (2019: 142).

2. NP + *=de* as a locative adjunct PP and the one-argument existential verb *aru*

In Japanese, PPs of the form "NP + *=de*" function generally as adjuncts. Accordingly, *kare=wa gakusei=de aru* is assumed to consist syntactically of a **mandatory structure** [*kare=wa aru*] and an **adjunct structure** [*gakusei=de*].

In *kare=wa aru*, the predicate *aru* — or, more precisely, its stem *ar-* — can thus be analysed as a **ONE-ARGUMENT verb**, taking only the NP *kare* as its argument. When the verb *aru* **functions as one-argument predicate**, it means '**to exist**' — though rather literary, as in *ware omou, yueni ware ari* 'I think, therefore I am' — and the sentence *kare=wa aru* can thus be interpreted as 'he exists', **asserting the existence** of *kare*. As for the PP *gakusei=de*, on the other hand, although **PPs headed by =de** can express a variety of semantic roles such as location, means or cause, in this case it can be interpreted as neither means nor cause. The most plausible interpretation is therefore **locative** — not a physical but a **conceptual location**.

² She argues that the ungrammaticality of **neko=de wagahai=ga aru* 'I am a cat' supports her claim that "the NP-*de* element must always be the phrase in the closest proximity to the verb". However, the ungrammaticality of this sentence does not arise from word order, but rather from the fact that *wagahai*, while functioning as a topic, is not marked by *=wa*. Indeed, although rather awkward, *neko=de wagahai=wa aru* is not completely ungrammatical, and expressions such as NP=*de* *watasi=wa ari-tai* 'as the referent denoted by the NP I want to exist' — e.g. *ryōsikiteki-na syakaizin=de watasi=wa ari-tai* 'as a rational member of society I want to exist' — sound much more natural.

Consequently, *gakusei=de* means 'in the conceptual domain "student"' or, more simply, 'as a student'. The entire structure *kare=wa gakusei=de aru* is thus, syntactically, composed of **the mandatory ONE-ARGUMENT clause** [*kare wa aru*] 'he exists' and **the ADJUNCT** [*gakusei=de*] 'in the conceptual domain "student"'. Semantically, it expresses 'He exists, and the location of his existence is the conceptual domain of "student"' or, more simply, 'He exists, and it is as a student'. Schematically, *A=wa B=de aru*, in which B is an adjunctive, can be represented as **$E(A) \wedge IN(A, B)$** , where $E(A)$ 'A exists' denotes **the assertion of existence** and $IN(A, B)$ 'A is in B' denotes **the specification of the domain of existence**. $E(A) \wedge IN(A, B)$ thus constitutes a conjunctive proposition. By contrast, *A=wa B=ni aru/iru*, in which B is an argument, can be represented as $IN(A, B)$ 'A is in B', which constitutes a simple proposition. The difference between the conjunctive $E(A) \wedge IN(A, B)$ and the simple $IN(A, B)$ is reflected in their default negation patterns, such as *A=wa B=de=wa nai* vs. *A=wa B=ni nai/i-nai*, which will be discussed in Section 7.

Thus, in place of the traditional **copula-based** analysis in (7) = (1):

- (7) *kare=wa gakusei dear-u*
 he(SUBJ)=TOP student(PRED) COP-PRES
 'He is a student.'

in this paper, a **one-argument-existential-verb-based** analysis is adopted, as in (8), where CONCEPT-LOC abbreviates 'conceptual-locative':

- (8) *kare=wa gakusei=de ar-u*
 he(SUBJ)=TOP student=CONCEPT-LOC(ADJUNCT) exist-PRES
 'He exists, and his existence is located in the conceptual domain of "student".'

3. The differences between *sore wa gakkō=DE ARu* and *sore wa gakkō=NI ARu*

In contrast to the construction *sore=wa gakkō=de aru* in (9), hypothesised as **existence-asserting and domain-specifying** in Section 2:

- (9) *sore=wa gakkō=de ar-u*
 it(SUBJ)=TOP school=CONCEPT-LOC(ADJUNCT) exist-PRES
 'It exists, and its existence is located in the conceptual domain of "school".'

in genuine locative — that is, **location-specifying** — constructions as in (10) and (11), where

PHYSIC-LOC abbreviates 'physical-locative':

- (10) sore=wa gakkō=**ni** **ar-u**
it(SUBJ)=TOP school=PHYSIC-LOC(ARGUMENT) be located-PRES
'It is in the school.'
- (11) kare=wa gakkō=**ni** **i-ru**
he(SUBJ)=TOP school=PHYSIC-LOC(ARGUMENT) be located-PRES
'He is in the school.'

the **physical-locative argument is obligatory and always marked by the postposition =ni, rather than =de**. The formal and semantic differences between (9) and (10) further support the above analysis. The verb *aru* — more precisely, its stem *ar-* — when used as a **LOCATIVE verb**, is a **TWO-ARGUMENT predicate with the argument structure [location, theme]**, the location being denoted by the postpositional phrase [NP + =ni], as in *sore=wa gakkō=**ni** aru*. When the theme is animate, the verb *iru* with the stem *i-* is used instead as in (11), with the argument PP [NP + =ni] unchanged, as in *kare=wa gakkō=**ni** iru* 'he is in the school', whereas the ungrammatical sentence in (12) which employs the PP [NP + =de]:

- (12) kare=wa gakkō=**de** **i-ru**
he(SUBJ)=TOP school=LOC(ADJUNCT) ?-PRES
' ? '

is not semantically interpretable — even for native speakers — and ungrammatical.

Accordingly, *kare=wa gakusei=de aru* should be regarded SYNTACTICALLY — though NOT PRAGMATICALLY OR INFORMATIONALLY, as will be discussed in Section 4 — as a **structurally self-contained existence-asserting clause** *kare=wa aru* 'he exists', **accompanied by the conceptual-locative adjunct** *gakusei=de*, **which specifies the domain of existence**.

4. The syntactic optionality and pragmatic necessity of *gakusei=de*

Although *gakusei=de* in *kare=wa gakusei=de aru* is **syntactically an adjunct**, it **cannot be deleted**. This is because the sentence, while structurally consisting of the mandatory core *kare=wa aru* 'he exists' and the adjunct *gakusei=de* 'in the conceptual domain "student"' or 'as a student', serves as a **presentational sentence** in which **the focus is on the adjunct** *gakusei=de*.

Therefore, the **non-deletability of** *gakusei=de* **arises from its pragmatic and informational**

indispensability rather than from syntactic necessity. The distinction can be represented as follows:

Level	Structure	Function
Syntax	[NP <i>A ar-</i>] + [PP <i>B=de</i>]	One-argument predicate + adjunct
Semantics	"A exists, and it is in the domain B"	Existence assertion + domain specification $E(A) \wedge IN(A, B)$
Information Structure	[<i>A=wa aru</i>] + [<i>B=de</i>]	Given + New (default)
Pragmatics	Focus on <i>B=de</i> (default)	Pragmatic obligatoriness and non-deletability of <i>B=de</i> due to focus

5. Shift of focus and foregrounding of the lexical meaning 'to exist' of the verb *aru*

In the construction *watasi=wa ryōsikiteki-na syakaizin=de aru* in (13):

- (13) *watasi=wa ryōsikitekina syakaizin=de ar-u*
 I(SUBJ)=TOP rational member of society=CONCEP-LOC(ADJUNCT) **exist**-PRES
 'I EXIST as a rational member of society.'

which can be schematically represented as $E(A) \wedge IN(A, B)$, the existence-asserting component $E(A)$ — the assertion of the lexical meaning 'to exist' encoded in the verbal stem *ar-* — is backgrounded as given information, while the domain-specifying component $IN(A, B)$ is foregrounded as the focus of the utterance. As a result, the meaning 'to exist' is rarely brought to the speaker's or hearer's awareness in ordinary predication contexts.

By contrast, in example (14), which takes the form **A WANT** [$E(A) \wedge IN(A, B)$], the situation is different:

- (14) *watasi=wa ryōsikitekina syakaizin=de ari-tai-0*
 I(SUBJ)=TOP rational member of society=CONCEP-LOC(ADJUNCT) **exist** want-PRES
 'I want to EXIST as a rational member of society.'

Here, what is at issue is 'one's mode of existence', that is, an orientation toward a particular manner of being. In such a context, $E(A)$ is **no longer backgrounded but instead becomes part of the focus as well as** $IN(A, B)$, and the lexical concept 'to exist' encoded in *ar-* emerges as perceptually salient. This pragmatic shift of focus, which foregrounds the existential meaning

of *ar-*, supports empirically the validity of analysing **the semantic structure of $A=wa\ B=de\ aru$ not as $BE(A, B)$ but as $EXIST(A) \wedge IN(A, B)$.**

It should be noted that the English translation 'I want to BE a rational member of society', represented as **A WANT [BECOME(A, B)]** — based on 'I AM a rational member of society', represented as **BE(A, B)** — is a complete mistranslation of the construction *watasi=wa ryōsikiteki-na syakaizin=de ari-tai* in (14). This in itself clearly demonstrates that the Japanese *=da/=de aru* is not equivalent to the English *to be*, nor does it function as a copula in the same way. The difference between them can be represented as in (15):

- | | |
|--|---|
| (15) <i>Watasi=wa ryōsikiteki-na syakaizin=de aru:</i> | EXIST(A) $\wedge$ IN(A, B) |
| I am a rational member of society: | BE(A, B) |
| <i>Watasi=wa ryōsikiteki-na syakaizin=de ari-tai:</i> | A WANT [EXIST(A) $\wedge$ IN(A, B)] |
| I want to be a rational member of society: | A WANT [BECOME(A, B)] |

What corresponds in Japanese to the English I want to be a rational member of society is (16):

- | | | | | |
|------|--|---|---------------|---------------|
| (16) | <i>watasi=wa</i> | <i>ryōsikitekina syakaizin=ni</i> | nari- | <i>-tai-0</i> |
| | I(SUBJ)=TOP | rational member of society=GOAL(ARGUMENT) | become | want-PRES |
| | 'I want to BE a rational member of society.' | | | |

Schematically, (16) denotes **A WANT [BECOME(A, B)]**, with the state-change verb *naru* 'to become', where *=ni* marks **GOAL(ARGUMENT)**.

6. Old Japanese forms

In Old Japanese, the modern *kare=wa gakusei=de aru* would correspond to *kare gakusei nari*³, derived from *kare gakusei=ni ari*, as Frellesvig, B. (2010: 95) noted: "*Ni ar-* sometimes phonologically fused to give *nar-*, ..., which in EMJ became a fully inflected copula" (EMJ

³ The form *gakusei* is assumed to have been *gakusyau* and did not denote a 'student' in the modern, general sense, but rather 'someone studying at *Daigakureu* — the central institution for the training of government officials' or a 'scholar-monk' (cf. Ōno et al. 1990). Likewise, *kare* has been used in the sense of the English *he* only since the Meiji period. Both *kare* and *gakusei* are thus employed here merely for convenience.

abbreviates Early Middle Japanese, 800-1200). "Dative *ni* is the general oblique case, marking both argument and non-argument oblique nominals" (ibid.: 126), unlike in Modern Japanese, where, generally, *=ni* marks arguments, while *=de* — which originated from the postposition-suffix sequence *=nite* — marks adjuncts. Thus, *kare gakusei=ni ari* can be analysed as consisting of the one-argument core clause *kare ari* 'he exists' and the locative adjunct *gakusei=ni* 'in the conceptual domain denoted by *gakusei*', as indicated in (17), which is consistent with the present hypothesis:

- (17) *kare* *gakusei=ni* *ari-0*
 it(SUBJ)=TOP school=CONCEP-LOC(ADJUNCT) exist-PRES
 'He exists, and it is as a student.'

The subsequent development *kare gakusei=nari* → *kare gakusei=nite ari* → *kare=wa gakusei=de aru* may reflect the diachronic split between *=ni*, used for arguments, and *=nite* — later, *=de* — used for adjuncts. This suggests a shift from a linguistic stage in which *=ni* marked both arguments and adjuncts to one in which *=ni* and *=nite/=de* became specialised as argumental and adjunctive markers, respectively — a possibility that merits further historical investigation.

7. Default partial negation and the scope of negation marked by the particle *=wa*

The **default negation pattern of the existence-asserting and domain-specifying** (18) = (8):

- (18) *kare=wa* *gakusei=de* *ar-u*
 he(SUBJ)=TOP student=CONCEP-LOC(ADJUNCT) exist-PRES
 'He exists, and it is as a student.'

which, in line with Section 2, can be schematically represented as the conjunctive $E(A) \wedge IN(A, B)$, is the **partial negation** shown in (19):

- (19) *kare=wa* *gakusei=de=wa* (*ara-) **-nai-0**
 he(SUBJ)=TOP student=CONCEP-LOC(ADJUNCT)=SCOPE OF NEG exist NEG-PRES
 'He exists, but it is not as a student.'

rather than the total negation in (20):

- (20) *kare=wa* *gakusei=de* (*ara-) **-nai-0**
 he(SUBJ)=TOP student=CONCEP-LOC(ADJUNCT) exist NEG-PRES
 'He does not exists as a student.'

(In (19) and (20), the stem of the existential verb *aru* is represented as (*ara-), since in contemporary Standard Japanese the negative form of this verb is not the theoretically expected **ara-nai*, but obligatorily the suppletive adjective *nai*.) The more natural sentence *kare=wa gakusei=de=wa nai* in (19) does **not negate the existence of *kare* itself**, but rather **negates only *gakusei=de* as the domain of existence**. In Japanese, thus, **the particle =wa can mark the scope of negation**.

Schematically, the partial negation *A=wa B=de=wa nai* in (19) — underlyingly, **A=wa B=de=wa ara-nai* — can be represented as $E(A) \wedge \neg IN(A, B)$, whereas the total negation *A=wa B=de nai* in (20) — underlyingly, **A=wa B=de ara-nai* — can be represented as $\neg(E(A) \wedge IN(A, B))$, that is, $\neg E(A) \vee \neg IN(A, B)$. Although this condition is compatible with $\neg E(A) \wedge IN(A, B)$, $E(A) \wedge \neg IN(A, B)$ or $\neg E(A) \wedge \neg IN(A, B)$, the first case is inconsistent given the semantic postulate $IN(A, B) \Rightarrow E(A)$ — hence $\neg E(A) \Rightarrow \neg IN(A, B)$ — and the option $\neg E(A) \wedge \neg IN(A, B) = \neg E(A)$ — namely, the third case — is pragmatically infelicitous in topicalised clauses with *A=wa*, since *A=wa*, as a topic phrase, tends to presuppose the discourse-givenness or existence of *A* and there are dedicated Japanese forms for existential negation such as *A wa nai/inai*; in practice, therefore, the interpretation converges on $E(A) \wedge \neg IN(A, B)$. Hence the former pattern in (19), which unambiguously denotes $E(A) \wedge \neg IN(A, B)$, is judged to be the more natural one.

If *=de aru* were a single copula, then *A=wa B=de aru* would denote $BE(A, B)$, and its negation would be plain predicate negation — namely, *A=wa B=de nai*, represented as $\neg BE(A, B)$, with no *=wa* after *=de*. **Empirically, nevertheless, *A=wa B=de nai* is felt to be infelicitous, whereas *A=wa B=de=wa nai* is preferred**. This obligatory *=wa* on *=de* is unexpected under the simple-copula analysis, but follows immediately if the clause decomposes as $E(A) \wedge IN(A, B)$ and the intended reading is the partial negation $E(A) \wedge \neg IN(A, B)$.

By contrast, the **default negation of the location-specifying** (21) and (22) = (10) and (11):

(21) *sore=wa gakkō=ni ar-u*
 it(SUBJ)=TOP school=PHYSIC-LOC(ARGUMENT) be located-PRES
 'It is in the school.'

(22) *kare=wa gakkō=ni i-ru*
 he(SUBJ)=TOP school=PHYSIC-LOC(ARGUMENT) be located-PRES
 'He is in the school.'

which can both be represented as $IN(A, B)$, is the **total negation** indicated in (23) and (24):

- | | | | | |
|------|----------------------------|-----------------------------|------------|--------------|
| (23) | sore=wa | gakkō=ni | (*ara-) | nai-0 |
| | it(SUBJ)=TOP | school=PHYSIC-LOC(ARGUMENT) | be located | NEG-PRES |
| | 'It is not in the school.' | | | |
| | | | | |
| (24) | kare=wa | gakkō=ni | i- | nai-0 |
| | he(SUBJ)=TOP | school=PHYSIC-LOC(ARGUMENT) | be located | NEG-PRES |
| | 'He is not in the school.' | | | |

Unlike the existence-assertion and domain-specifying conjunctive $E(A) \wedge IN(A, B)$, the location-specifying $IN(A, B)$ is a simple proposition and, naturally, its negation constitutes $\neg IN(A, B)$, which corresponds to (23) and (24).

The difference in default negation pattern between the existence-asserting and domain-specifying construction and the purely location-specifying one lies in the fact that the former, $E(A) \wedge IN(A, B)$, is conjunctive, whereas the latter, $IN(A, B)$, is simplex. This ultimately derives from the status of B as an adjunct in the former and as an argument in the latter, since if B were an argument, $E(A) \wedge IN(A, B)$ would correspond to $EXIST\text{-}MANNER(A, B)$, whose negation would be the total $\neg EM(A, B)$.

Finally, Furthermore, if *=de aru* were a single copular unit, partial negation with *=wa* would necessarily take the form **kare=wa gakusei=**wa** de nai*, as in (25):

- (25) *kare=wa gakusei=**wa** de **nai-0**
 he(SUBJ)=TOP student(PRED)=**SCOPE OF NEGATION** COP **NEG-PRES**
 'He is not a student, but something else.'

The fact that this is ungrammatical further supports the separability of *=de* and *aru* and the adjunctive nature of *gakusei=de*.

8. The contracted form $=da$

In spoken language, the contracted form =*da* is often used instead of =*de aru*, which is more formal and literal, as in *kare=wa gakusei=**da*** 'he is a student'. It should be noted that this **contracted form =da** does not represent a new copular category but a **purely phonological reduction of the postpositional-verbal complex =de aru**, as shown in (26):

- (26) kare=wa gakusei=**d** **a-0**
he(SUBJ)=TOP student=**CONCEP-LOC**(ADJUNCT) **exist-PRES**
'He exists, and it is as a student.'

The historical change from *=de aru* to *=da*, possibly via *=dea*⁴, involves no syntactic or semantic reanalysis, but only a process of phonetic contraction comparable to French *à le* → *au* 'to the' or Portuguese *de a* → *da* 'from the, of the'. Just as there is no semantic necessity for *à* and *le* to fuse into *au*, or for *de* and *a* into *da* — a phenomenon comparable to the English *to the* or *from the* forming a single word — there is likewise no semantic motivation for *=de* and *aru* to form a single lexical item.

The two elements remain distinct in their underlying structure: *=de* functions as a postposition indicating the domain in which existence holds, and the stem of *aru* as the existential verb itself. This is precisely why the following highly colloquial dialogue in (27) is possible:

(27) Kare=tte gakusei=**da** yone? — Iya, gakusei=tte yū=ka, gakusei=**de=mo aru**=tte kanzi kana.

'He's a student, right?' — 'Well, if you can call him a student, I'd say he's *also* a student, kind of.'

In this dialogue, the interlocutor, recognising that the underlying structure of *gakusei=da* is *gakusei=de aru*, when asked to confirm that *kare*'s domain of existence can be identified as that of 'student', replies that his existence extends to other domains as well, expressed by the form *gakusei=de=mo aru*.

Returning to Section 1, *kare=wa gakusei=de, kanozyo=wa syakaizin=da* 'he (is) a student, and she is a professional' is thus, underlyingly, a compound sentence *kare=wa gakusei=de ari, kanozyo=wa syakaizin=de aru*, in which the first predicate *ari* is deleted as recoverable, based on the structural parallelism between the two coordinate clauses, as indicated in (28):

(28) kare=wa gakusei=de (**ari**) kanozyo=wa syakaizin=d **a-0**
 he(SUBJ)=TOP student=LOC(ADJC) (**exist**) she(SUBJ)=TOP professional=LOC(ADJC) **exist-PRES**
 'He (**exists**) as a student, she **exists** as a professional.'

(28) is an instance of zeugma, so *=de* is not an inflected form of *=da*. Therefore, *=da* as a whole should not be regarded as a copula in the strict sense, but as a **phonologically reduced surface realisation of the underlying construction *=de aru*** — more theoretically, *=de ar-0*, where *ar-* and *-0* represent the stem of the existential verb *aru* and a phonologically zero tense suffix

⁴ Historically, the form *=dea*, which yielded the modern *=da*, can be attested in Azuchi–Momoyama-period materials: *bonnin yorimo giūzaini fuxōzuru cotodea* '(it) is a reason for imposing a heavier guilt (on him) than on an ordinary person' (Amakusa Edition of *Esopo no fabulas*, 1593, p.475, ll.10-11, in Text Data Sets for Research on the History of Japanese).

specified as [-past].

9. Conclusion — *=da* not as a copula but as the conceptual-locative postposition *=de* followed by the one-argument existential verb *aru*

To summarise, the syntactic structure of *A=wa B dearu* 'A is B' consists of a **mandatory existence-asserting clause** [*A=wa aru*] 'A exists' and a **domain-specifying adjunct** [*B=de*] 'in the conceptual domain denoted by B' or 'as B'. It should therefore be syntactically represented as *A=wa B=de aru*. Consequently, treating *dearu* or its contracted form *da* as a single copula is structurally problematic. The form *dearu* is more appropriately analysed as an **existence-domain complex**, composed of the existential verb *aru* and the postpositional phrase *B=de*, which specifies the domain in which the existence of *A* is realised. The more colloquial form *=da* is a phonologically contracted form corresponding to the more formal and literal *=de aru*.

Thus, through the above syntactic analysis, it has been possible to account, by means of a single, consistent principle — namely, the **assertion of existence by** [*NP₁=wa + ar-*] and the **specification of the domain of existence by** [*NP₂ + =de*], schematically represented by **E(NP₁) $\wedge$ IN(NP₁, NP₂)** — for:

- Separability between *de* and *aru* in *dearu*
- Inseparability between NPs and *de*
- Optional omission of *aru* in *dearu*
- Foregrounding of the lexical meaning 'to exist' of the verb *aru*
- Grounds on which the Japanese *=de ari-tai* is not equivalent to the English *to want to be*
- Historical development *A B=ni ari* $\rightarrow$ *A B=nari* $\rightarrow$ *A B=nite ari* $\rightarrow$ *A=wa B=de aru*
- Grounds on which the default negation of *A=wa B=de aru* is not the total *A=wa B=de nai* but the partial *A=wa B=de=wa nai*
- Underlying structure of *=da* as *=de aru*

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